

British primatologist Jane Goodall is the world's primary expert on chimpanzees. Her study of their behavior, which lasted more than 55 years, led to discoveries that fueled her ongoing campaign for animal welfare and conservation.

MILESTONES

STUDIES CHIMPANZEES

Begins a 6-month trip to Tanzania in 1960, studying families of chimpanzees and researching their behavior.

PRESENTS FINDINGS

Gives her first lecture in 1964 reporting on research; this leads to her becoming a public figure.

BECOMES A DOCTOR

Gains PhD in ethology from Cambridge University in 1965 despite not having a degree as an undergraduate.

PROTECTS SPECIES

Founds the Jane Goodall Institute in 1977 to promote research, education, and chimpanzee conservation.

INSPIRES TEACHERS

Establishes the Roots and Shoots program in 1991, training young people to be conservation leaders.

Aged just 26, Jane Goodall traveled to Gombe National Park in Tanzania for a 6-month program to study the behavior of chimpanzees. The Kenyan paleontologist Louis Leakey secured funds for this trip, having seen Goodall's potential and already sent her to London in 1958 to study primate anatomy and behavior.

Kindred spirits

With natural patience, tenacity, and empathy, Goodall overcame initial rejection from the animals and was eventually accepted into the chimpanzee community. Her 6-month placement extended into decades of detailed research that revealed for the first time the personalities, emotions, and social behaviors demonstrated by chimpanzees. Her key discoveries included that chimpanzees are omnivorous, hunt cooperatively, and wage war with one another—traits previously believed to be displayed only by humans. Furthermore, she noted their close similarities to humans in terms of their emotional behavior (both positive and negative), intelligence, social structure, and relationship-building.

In 1977, Goodall founded the Jane Goodall Institute, now a global organization that promotes her conservation campaign, and today, she is a world leader for the protection of chimpanzees and their environments. As a pioneering woman in a male-dominated world, she is an inspirational figure for a new generation of scientists.

Goodall observed that chimpanzees utilize tools, such as stripping a stick to gather food, revealing similarities between chimpanzee and human behavior.

